TALK SIX

6 Art Thou He That Should Come?

"Art thou he that should come? or look we for another?"

LUKE 7:19

From prison, John the Baptist sent two disciples to Jesus to ask a question. *Tell Him John said to ask: "Art thou he that should come? or look we for another?"* John had baptized Jesus and told his followers, "Behold the Lamb of God." But there, in prison, he needed to know for sure. I think he wanted to know he had accomplished the work he'd been given.

John was in prison because he confronted a powerful ruler. Herod Antipas was a son of the Herod who had killed John's father. Antipas married Herodias, his brother's wife, while that brother was still alive. Josephus says Herodias broke the law by leaving her husband while he was alive, and the law of Moses forbade a man to marry his brother's wife. John told Herod plainly, "It is not lawful for thee to have thy brother's wife." Herod's position did not put him above the law of Moses, and John called the sin what it was. George A. Smith described John as bold enough "to rebuke the king on his throne, to his face, for adultery." Adultery was punishable by death under the law of Moses.

Herod also feared the influence John had over the people. The Jewish historian Josephus writes that Herod worried the crowds might follow John into a revolt. His men bound John and took him to Machaerus, a fortress on a mountain east of the Dead Sea. Herod's father had built it on a rocky peak surrounded by deep valleys.

Inside Herod's household, people disagreed about what to do with John. Herodias wanted him dead, but Herod knew he was "a just man and an holy man." Mark says Herod feared him and even liked listening to him. He kept John alive, but to satisfy Herodias, he also kept John in prison. However, John's disciples could still visit and bring news of Jesus's ministry. Through

them, he heard what Jesus was doing, and he sent two of them to ask his question.

Jesus performed a miracle for the messengers to witness before sending them back. Luke says that during that hour He healed many people. Then He told them, "Go your way, and tell John what things ye have seen and heard." The blind could see, the lame could walk, lepers were cleansed, the deaf could hear, the dead were raised, and the poor heard the gospel. John knew the words of Isaiah about God coming to save His people: blind eyes would open, and the lame would leap. The messengers could tell him that those promises were being fulfilled. They had seen it.

But the last thing Jesus named, the gospel preached to the poor, comes from a single verse in Isaiah, one John would have known. In that verse the Lord's anointed one is sent "to preach good tidings unto the meek," "to bind up the brokenhearted," and "to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to them that are bound." Jesus used the beginning of that verse and stopped before the end of it. He did not tell John's disciples that the prison would be opened. Instead He added, "And blessed is he, whosoever shall not be offended in me." *Offended* here means caused to stumble. Jesus was telling John that He was the one, and that faith would mean trusting Him while the prison door stayed shut. John's own circumstances would not change with Jesus's answer. He stayed in prison.

After the messengers left, Jesus spoke about the kind of man John was. He asked what they had gone into the wilderness to see. A reed blown about by the wind? Someone dressed in soft clothing? People like that lived in kings' palaces. John had never dressed for a palace or changed his message to please a ruler. Jesus asked whether they had gone to see a prophet, then answered, "Yea, I say unto you, and much more than a prophet." He identified John as the Elias messenger Malachi promised would prepare the way. Then He said, "Among those that are born of women there is not a greater prophet than John the Baptist." John's messengers had already left. He likely never heard what his Lord said about him.

Joseph Smith explained John's greatness through the responsibilities God entrusted to him. John received "a divine mission of preparing the way before the face of the Lord." He was called "to baptize the Son of Man." He

was also “the only legal administrator” on earth at that time, holding the keys of power. When Jesus added that “he that is least in the kingdom of God is greater than he,” Joseph Smith taught that Jesus was speaking of Himself. People regarded Jesus as having the least claim to be a prophet, yet He was greater than John. John’s greatness came through faithfully serving the right Master.

John’s life ended with execution. Herod chose to keep a reckless promise rather than protect a man he knew was holy. At a birthday supper for his officials and the leading men of Galilee, Herod was pleased by the dancing of Herodias’s daughter, Salome. In front of his guests, he promised her whatever she asked in exchange for the dance--up to half his kingdom. She consulted her mother and returned, asking for John’s head. Herod was sorry, but he would not take back his oath before the men at his table. He sent a soldier to execute John, and the head was brought to the girl on a platter. She gave it to her mother.

John’s disciples buried his body and then went to tell Jesus. When Jesus heard, He withdrew by boat to a quiet place. His cousin and friend, the man who had prepared His way, baptized Him, and directed disciples to Him, was gone. John’s death also remained in the memory of the people. Josephus records that years later, when Herod’s army suffered defeat, some Jews believed it was God’s punishment for killing John.

John once said he was not worthy to untie the sandals of the Lord coming after him. He gave the Lord his allegiance when crowds wanted to follow him, and he continued to turn to Him when he was alone in prison. His service did not spare him suffering, and the answer he received did not open the prison door. But Jesus knew who John was and what he had done. While John waited, the Lord spoke of him as a prophet without equal.

I may not always receive the answer I hope for either. John’s question helps me see that I can bring mine to Jesus. I want to keep turning to Him when I do not understand what is happening, and keep following Him while I wait.

[The speaker continues with his own testimony.]

◆ ◆ ◆

The script ends here. The speaker’s own testimony follows.